

Rough



Lapis rough | This piece of lapis lazuli rough consists of areas of rich blue colouring, along with large cross-veining of calcite and some substantial inclusions of pyrite. This material could be cut into interesting cabochons.

Calcite veining

Deep blue material



Streaked rough | The rich blue of this substantial piece of lapis lazuli rough – slightly larger than a fist – is accentuated by streaks and scatters of golden pyrite.



Lapis rough | Some lapis rough is almost devoid of pyrite, as in this specimen. It is often preferred for use in inlaid carvings and small cabochons.

Cut



Polished lapis | Lapis polished in irregular forms, such as this wedge-shaped piece, are desirable decorative objects even without a jewellery setting.



Imitation lapis | Created by Gilson, this cabochon is cut from imitation lapis. It can be identified as synthetic by its uniform colour and unnatural scatter of pyrite.



Chilean cabochon | While ancient lapis came from Afghanistan, the New World source is in Chile. Its material tends to be lighter in colour, such as in this cabochon.

Settings



Lapis ring | The square cabochon set in this 18-karat gold ring has fine colour, and includes a beautiful scatter of bright gold pyrite.



Ancient eagle | Originating from the Sumerian civilization around 2650 BCE, this lion-headed eagle is created from lapis lazuli, gold, copper, and bitumen.



Copper antlers

Bust of Mehurt | From the Old Kingdom of ancient Egypt (c.1539–1075 BCE) comes this head of Mehurt, the celestial mother, made of lapis, copper, and gold.

The therapeutic stone

Lapis lazuli in ancient treatments

The Greek physician Dioscorides noted in around 55 CE that lapis was an antidote for snake venom; even earlier than this, the Assyrians used it as a cure for melancholy. Another widespread ancient belief was that it protected the wearer from evil because it resembled the night sky, the dwelling place of God. Similarly, a medieval treatise suggests that “meditation upon stone carries the soul to heavenly contemplation”, while to the Buddhists of antiquity, lapis lazuli brought peace of mind.



Ancient remedy | Ground lapis lazuli, which was sometimes administered as a “medication”.